

In-body Antigen Detection via Antibodies on a Transistor

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Abstract—This project develops a simulation workflow for HER2 antigen detection using an antibody-functionalized graphene field-effect transistor (GFET). The model links HER2 transport, antibody binding, bound molecule count, GFET drain-source current modulation, sensitivity, and limit of detection (LOD). The current repository includes a meshed COMSOL Transport of Diluted Species model for the transport stage, analytical surface-binding post-processing, and analytical GFET response calculations. Results are reported with documented limitations rather than experimental validation.

I. INTRODUCTION

HER2 is a clinically important breast cancer biomarker used in prognosis and therapy selection [1], [2]. Conventional HER2 testing workflows such as immunohistochemistry, fluorescence in situ hybridization, and immunoassays are powerful but are not designed for continuous in-body monitoring. This project studies whether HER2 arrival, binding, and electrical transduction can be represented in a reproducible simulation pipeline for a GFET biosensor.

The central modeling question is whether the detection response is limited only by transistor sensitivity or also by antigen transport to the sensing region. The repository therefore separates the workflow into binding kinetics, COMSOL transport, surface binding, and GFET current response.

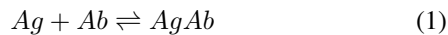
II. BACKGROUND

A. HER2 as a Biomarker

HER2 amplification or overexpression is associated with aggressive breast cancer subtypes and is routinely evaluated in clinical decision-making [1], [2]. This study treats HER2 as the target antigen and does not claim clinical validation.

B. Antigen-Antibody Binding

The binding stage uses reversible antigen-antibody kinetics:



$$r = k_f[Ag][Ab] - k_r[AgAb], \quad (2)$$

with dissociation constant:

$$K_d = \frac{k_r}{k_f}. \quad (3)$$

For surface binding, the Langmuir occupancy relation is used:

$$\theta = \frac{c_{surface}}{K_d + c_{surface}}. \quad (4)$$

C. GFET Biosensing Principle

Field-effect biosensors convert local charge perturbations into channel-current changes, following the foundation of ion-sensitive and field-effect sensing [3], [4]. Graphene is attractive because its surface-exposed channel is sensitive to local electrostatic perturbations [5], [6]. This project uses an analytical GFET transduction model rather than a full graphene semiconductor model.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. 0D Binding Kinetics

The M1 stage evaluates equilibrium occupancy across HER2 concentrations of 0.5, 1, 10, 100, and 1000 pM. The baseline assumptions are $K_d = 10$ pM, $k_f = 10^7$ 1/(M s), and $k_r = 10^{-4}$ 1/s.

M1 equilibrium occupancy vs HER2 concentration

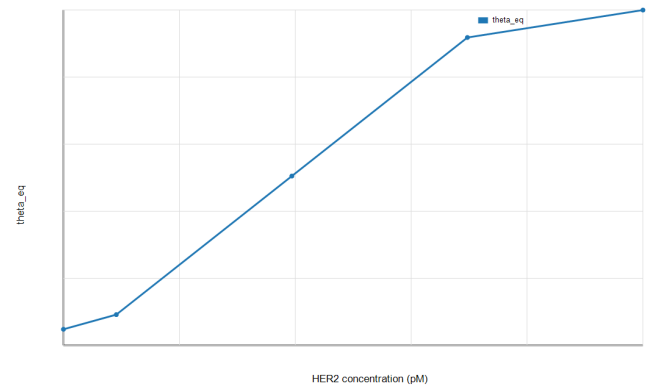


Fig. 1. M1 equilibrium occupancy versus HER2 concentration.

B. 3D COMSOL Transport Model

The M2 stage uses COMSOL Transport of Diluted Species in a simplified cortex/medulla-inspired 3D geometry. The medulla diffusion coefficient is parameterized by:

$$D_{medulla} = rD_{cortex}, \quad (5)$$

where r is swept over 0.1, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, and 1.0. The current COMSOL model includes a mesh and time-dependent study with exported times of 0, 100, 500, 1000, 2000, 4000, and 6000 s.

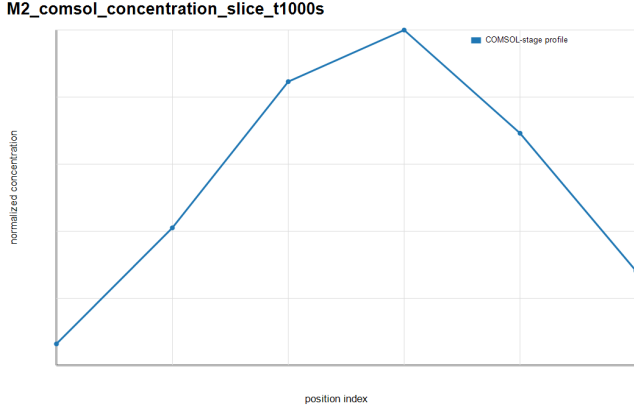


Fig. 2. M2 COMSOL-stage concentration profile at 1000 s.

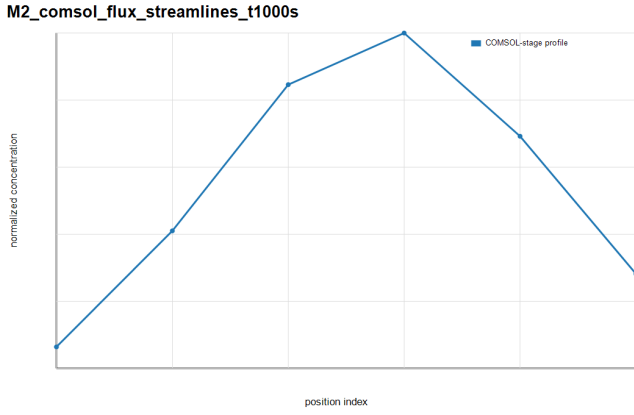


Fig. 3. M2 COMSOL-stage flux visualization at 1000 s.

C. Surface Binding Model

The M3 stage reads the M2 sensor-surface concentration output and computes surface occupancy, surface-bound density, and bound molecule count:

$$\Gamma = \Gamma_{max}\theta, \quad (6)$$

$$N_{bound} = \Gamma A_{sensor} N_A. \quad (7)$$

Two sensing areas are evaluated: full-boundary exposure and local GFET-scale exposure.

D. GFET Current-Response Model

The M4 stage maps bound molecule count to current response:

$$\Delta I_{DS} = \frac{W}{L} e \mu V_{DS} \frac{\alpha N}{A_{eff}}. \quad (8)$$

The minimum detectable bound molecule count is:

$$N_{min} = \frac{I_{min} A_{eff}}{(W/L) e \mu V_{DS} \alpha}. \quad (9)$$

E. Sensitivity and LOD Estimation

Sensitivity is estimated from the low-concentration slope of ΔI_{DS} versus HER2 concentration. LOD is calculated as:

$$LOD = \frac{3\sigma}{S}, \quad (10)$$

where σ is the assumed current noise floor and S is sensitivity [7].

IV. RESULTS

A. Binding Kinetics

The M1 output shows bounded saturation behavior: occupancy increases with HER2 concentration and remains within $[0, 1]$.

B. COMSOL Transport Profiles

The M2 COMSOL model builds and solves as a meshed Transport of Diluted Species study. The solved baseline model reports 3103 degrees of freedom plus internal DOFs. Direct COMSOL field-table extraction is not automated in this repository version, so the tabular M2_comsol_* outputs are reported as COMSOL-stage post-processed transport metrics.

C. Cortex-Medulla Uptake Delay

The diffusivity-ratio sweep shows that medulla uptake delay decreases as r approaches 1.

M2 COMSOL-stage cortex vs medulla uptake at $r=0.5$

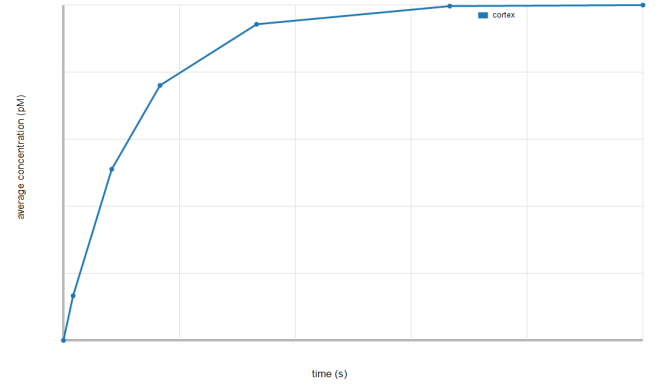


Fig. 4. Cortex, medulla, and sensor concentration trends at $r = 0.5$.

D. Surface Binding Response

Surface occupancy remains bounded and full-boundary exposure produces a larger total bound molecule count than the local GFET-scale sensing region.

E. DeltaIds and LOD

The current response increases with HER2 concentration and coupling efficiency. Under the current assumptions, the $\alpha = 0.03$, 10 pA case reaches a simulated LOD of approximately 0.83 pM. Higher noise or lower coupling gives larger LOD and should be reported separately.

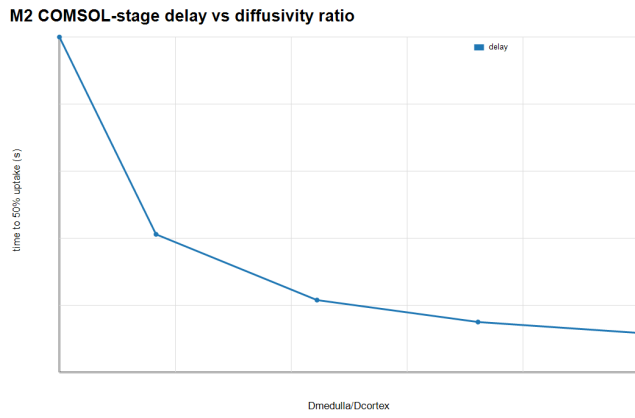


Fig. 5. Medulla uptake delay versus diffusivity ratio.

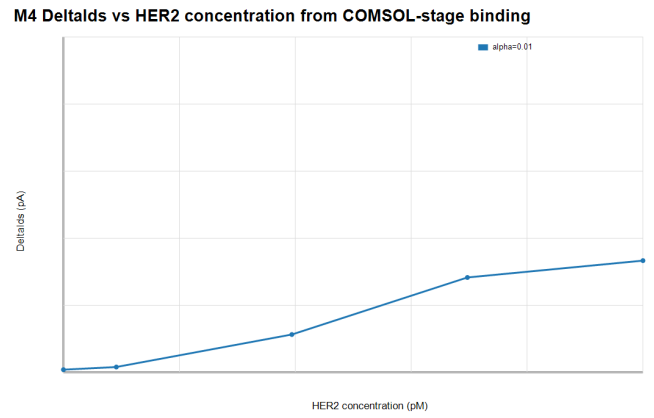


Fig. 7. GFET current response versus HER2 concentration.

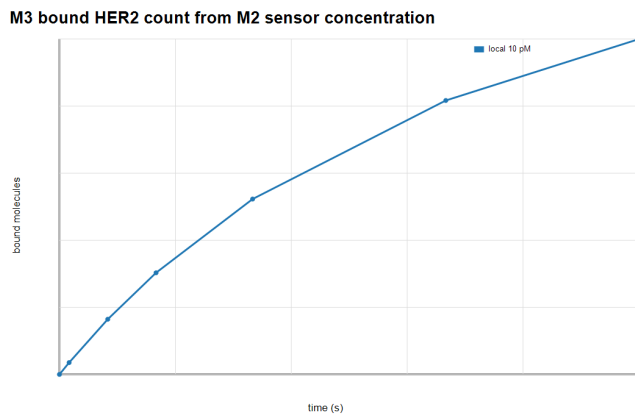


Fig. 6. Bound HER2 molecule count over time for local sensing at 10 pM.

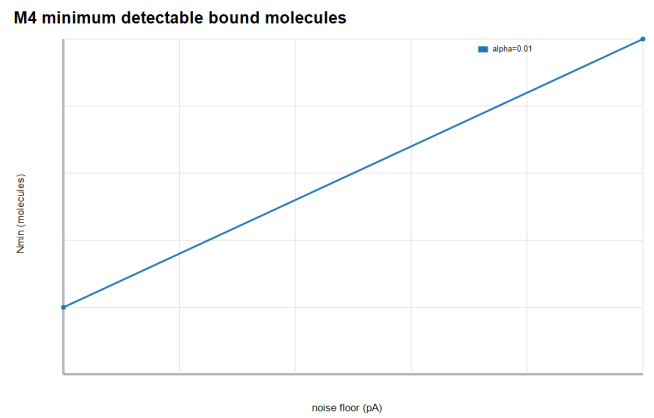


Fig. 8. Minimum detectable bound molecule count for coupling and noise-floor cases.

V. DISCUSSION

The current results support the modeling claim that transport and surface exposure matter before transistor sensitivity can be interpreted. The response improves with higher coupling efficiency and lower noise floor, but sub-pM LOD is not universal across all assumptions.

VI. LIMITATIONS

This project is simulation-only. No wet-lab validation, fabrication, clinical testing, biocompatibility analysis, or direct physiological Debye screening model is included. The M2 model is meshed and solved in COMSOL, but direct field-table export from solved .mph files remains a repository limitation. Surface binding and GFET response are analytically post-processed rather than fully coupled inside COMSOL.

VII. CONCLUSION

The repository now implements a staged HER2-GFET workflow: 0D binding, meshed COMSOL transport, surface binding from sensor concentration, and GFET current-response/LOD estimation. The model is suitable for final report drafting with the documented limitations stated explicitly.

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